The Fork in the Road:

How LibreOffice Was Born from a Crisis of Trust

“A Case Study in Open Source Governance, Community, and the Ethics of Control!”

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Section A: Establishing the Context

The story of LibreOffice does not begin with conflict—it begins with a promise. In the late 1990s and early 2000s, Microsoft Office had almost complete control over the office software market. It was expensive and worked best on Windows, which created serious limitations for students, governments, and organizations, especially in developing countries. In response to this, Sun Microsystems acquired StarOffice and made a bold move: it released the software as open source under the name OpenOffice.org. This decision gave people access to a free and flexible alternative, and naturally, a strong community of developers and contributors began to grow around it.

Fig 1: OpenOffice.org Interface – An Early Open Source Office Suite

At first glance, OpenOffice.org appeared to be a successful example of open source collaboration. Thousands of developers contributed their time and skills, and millions of users benefited from it. However, beneath this success, there was a structural issue that many contributors were uncomfortable with, but often ignored. The core problem was governance. Although the software was open source, Sun Microsystems retained significant control over the project. Developers who contributed code had to sign a Joint Copyright Assignment agreement, which meant that their work was not entirely their own—Sun also held rights over it. Additionally, Sun controlled the release process, feature approvals, and overall direction of the project.

This created a hidden imbalance. On paper, the project was open and collaborative. In reality, decision-making power was centralized within a single corporation. This structure made the eventual fork not only possible but almost inevitable. Contributors were investing their time and effort, but they did not have proportional influence over

the project's future. As long as Sun maintained a relatively cooperative relationship with the community, this issue remained manageable. However, the foundation was already unstable.

The real turning point came in 2010, when Oracle Corporation acquired Sun Microsystems. Unlike Sun, which had at least some alignment with open source values, Oracle had a reputation for being highly profit-driven and protective of its intellectual property. This shift in ownership changed how the community perceived the project. The same governance issues that existed under Sun suddenly became much more serious under Oracle. The copyright assignment clause, which was previously tolerated, now felt risky. Contributors were no longer just sharing their work with a relatively open-minded company they were handing over rights to a corporation known for aggressive legal strategies.

Interestingly, Oracle did not make any drastic or immediate changes to OpenOffice.org. However, its actions and in some cases, its lack of action gradually eroded trust. Communication with the community became weaker, decisions were made internally, and Oracle began treating the project more like a commercial asset than a shared community effort. This shows that the trigger for the fork was not just a policy change, but a shift in trust and perception. What had been a manageable concern under Sun became unacceptable under Oracle because the intentions behind control were now viewed differently.

This situation highlights an important distinction between legal openness and practical openness. Legally, OpenOffice.org was still open source. Anyone could access the code, modify it, and even fork it. But in practice, the community had very limited control over the project's direction. True openness is not just about access to code—it also involves participation in decision-making. Without that, open source can begin to resemble a controlled system, despite having an open license.

In summary, the LibreOffice fork was not a sudden or emotional decision. It was the result of long-standing structural issues that were exposed and intensified by a change in corporate ownership. The combination of centralized governance, copyright control, and loss of trust created a situation where the community felt it had no real alternative but to break away and build something independent.

Finally, this entire situation teaches that open source is not just about making code available it is about building a system where contributors feel respected, heard, and fairly treated. Without that, even the most successful projects can collapse from within.

Continuing from this, it also becomes clear that the LibreOffice case was not just a technical shift but a turning point in how people understand open source itself. Before this, many users and even developers assumed that if a project was open source, it automatically meant fairness, transparency, and shared control. However, this incident proved that openness in code does not always translate to openness in power. A project can appear open on the surface while still being tightly controlled behind the scenes.

This realization forced the community to rethink what truly matters in an open source project. It is not only about access to source code, but also about who gets to make decisions, whose voice is heard, and whether contributors are treated as equal participants or just as free labor. In the case of OpenOffice.org, contributors slowly started to feel that they were contributing to something they did not really own or influence, which created a sense of disconnect.

Moreover, the LibreOffice fork highlighted the importance of independence in community-driven projects. By creating The Document Foundation, the contributors were not just starting a new software they were building a system designed to avoid the same mistakes. They wanted a structure where no single company could dominate, and where decisions would be made collectively rather than imposed from the top. This shift shows that governance is just as important as technology in determining the success of an open source project.

It also shows that sometimes taking a difficult decision, like forking a well-established project, is necessary for long-term sustainability. Even though forking comes with risks such as division and uncertainty, it can also create an opportunity to rebuild things in a better and more balanced way. In this case, the community chose long-term control and fairness over short-term stability and convenience.

In conclusion, the situation that led to the LibreOffice fork was a combination of structural flaws, loss of trust, and a deeper realization about what open source should truly represent. It was not just about reacting to Oracle’s actions, but about correcting a system that was never fully balanced from the beginning.

Section B: The Ethics of Corporate Control

The question of whether a corporation has the right to control an open source project it invests in is deeply complex and cannot be answered in a simple yes or no. It lies somewhere between economics, ethics, and practical reality. In the case of OpenOffice.org, I take a clear position: while corporate involvement is necessary and often beneficial for the growth and sustainability of open source projects, the level of control exercised by Sun Microsystems and later by Oracle was ethically unjustified because it treated a community-driven project as a corporate asset rather than a shared ecosystem.

To begin with, it is important to understand the strongest argument in favor of corporate control. Companies like Sun invest significant resources into open source projects. These investments are not limited to money; they include infrastructure, paid developers, legal frameworks, marketing, and long-term maintenance. Without such support, many large-scale projects might struggle to survive or grow. From this perspective, it seems reasonable that a company would expect some level of authority over the project it is funding. After all, no organization would invest heavily in something over which it has no control or influence.

However, this argument becomes less convincing when we examine how value is actually created in open source projects like OpenOffice.org. While Sun provided the initial platform and continued support, a large portion of the innovation, bug fixes, translations, and improvements came from unpaid contributors. These individuals were not employees; they were volunteers who believed in the idea of open collaboration. Their motivation was not financial gain but the satisfaction of contributing to something meaningful and widely used. In such a scenario, allowing a single corporation to retain dominant control over the project creates a clear imbalance. The people who are doing a significant part of the work do not have an equal say in how that work is used or directed.

This imbalance raises a deeper ethical concern: is it fair for a company to benefit from community labor while maintaining authority over it? One could argue that contributors willingly agreed to these terms, including the copyright assignment. But consent alone does not make a system fair, especially when contributors may not fully understand the long-term implications of such agreements. Many contributors joined OpenOffice.org because it was “open source,” assuming a level of shared ownership and participation. The reality, however, was that their contributions strengthened a system they did not control.

Fig 2: Ethical Balance Between Corporate Control and Community Contribution

The copyright assignment clause is perhaps the most controversial aspect of this situation. By requiring contributors to sign over joint rights to their code, Sun ensured that it and later Oracle would have legal authority over all contributions. From a corporate perspective, this might have been seen as necessary for managing the project and avoiding legal complications. But from an ethical standpoint, it creates a problematic dynamic. Contributors are essentially giving away partial ownership of their work to a company that may use it for purposes they do not agree with. This became especially concerning after Oracle acquired Sun, because Oracle had a reputation for aggressively protecting and monetizing intellectual property.

This is where the difference between Sun and Oracle becomes important. Under Sun, the copyright assignment was uncomfortable but tolerated because the company was perceived as relatively aligned with open source values. Contributors trusted that Sun would not misuse its control. However, when Oracle took over, that trust disappeared. The same policy that once seemed acceptable suddenly felt dangerous. This highlights a key ethical insight: systems that depend on trust rather than fairness are inherently fragile. When the people in control change, the entire system can become unstable.

Another important concept in this discussion is the difference between stewardship and ownership. A steward is someone who takes care of something on behalf of others, with responsibility and accountability. An owner, on the other hand, has the right to control and use something as they see fit. In an ideal open source project, companies should act as stewards, not owners. They should guide the project, provide resources, and support the community, but they should not dominate decision-making or claim disproportionate control.

In the case of OpenOffice.org, Sun and later Oracle blurred this distinction. They acted not just as supporters but as controllers. They decided what features would be included, when releases would happen, and how the project would evolve. This

centralized authority reduced the role of the community and made contributors feel like they were working under a system they did not influence. Over time, this undermined the very spirit of open source collaboration.

At the same time, it would be unrealistic to argue that corporations should have no control at all. Completely decentralized systems can face problems such as lack of direction, inefficiency, and internal conflicts. Some level of structure and leadership is necessary for large projects to function effectively. However, the key issue is not whether corporations should have control, but how much control they should have and how that control is exercised.

A more ethical approach would involve shared governance, where decision-making power is distributed among different stakeholders, including independent contributors. Mechanisms such as elected committees, transparent processes, and limits on corporate influence can help maintain balance. This is exactly what the LibreOffice project tried to achieve after the fork, by ensuring that no single entity could dominate the governance structure.

In conclusion, while corporations have a legitimate interest in the projects they invest in, this does not justify the level of control that was exercised in the case of OpenOffice.org. The ethical problem was not corporate involvement itself, but the imbalance of power between the corporation and the community. When contributors feel that their work is being controlled rather than shared, trust breaks down, and the project suffers. The LibreOffice fork serves as a clear example of what happens when that balance is lost. It shows that for open source to truly remain “open,” governance must be as inclusive and fair as the code itself.

It also becomes important to consider how power is perceived, not just how it is structured. In many open source projects, contributors are willing to accept some level of corporate involvement as long as they feel respected and included. The problem in the OpenOffice.org case was not only that Sun and Oracle had control, but that the community increasingly felt excluded from meaningful participation. When decisions are taken behind closed doors, even a technically open project begins to feel closed in practice. This gap between perception and reality plays a huge role in shaping trust.

Another angle to this issue is long-term sustainability. A system where one company holds most of the control may work in the short term, especially if that company is stable and cooperative. However, it becomes risky over time because the entire project’s future becomes dependent on that single entity. The moment ownership changes as it did when Oracle acquired Sun the entire balance of the system is disturbed. Contributors suddenly find themselves working under a new authority that they did not choose and may not trust. This lack of stability makes centralized corporate control ethically questionable, because it exposes the community to risks beyond their control.

There is also a psychological aspect to consider. Open source contributors are not just workers; they are participants in a shared vision. They contribute because they believe they are part of something open, fair, and collaborative. When that belief is

challenged, it affects motivation. In the case of OpenOffice.org, many contributors did not leave immediately because of a single policy. Instead, their confidence slowly decreased over time, and the Oracle acquisition simply accelerated a process that had already begun. This shows that ethical concerns in open source are not always visible at first they build gradually and eventually reach a breaking point.

Furthermore, the situation highlights the difference between legal rights and moral rights. Legally, Sun and Oracle had the right to control the project and use the contributions as they saw fit, because contributors had agreed to those terms. But morally, the situation is less clear. Just because something is legally allowed does not mean it is ethically justified. The contributors were the ones creating value, yet they had limited influence over how that value was used. This disconnect between legal structure and moral fairness is at the heart of the conflict.

It is also worth noting that corporate control can unintentionally discourage future contributors. When developers see that their work might be controlled or owned by a single company, they may hesitate to participate. This can slow down innovation and reduce the diversity of ideas within the project. Open source thrives on collaboration and freedom, and any system that restricts these elements—even indirectly—can weaken the project over time.

In contrast, a more balanced governance model can actually benefit both the company and the community. When contributors feel that their voices matter, they are more likely to stay engaged and continue contributing. This creates a healthier ecosystem where innovation is driven not just by corporate goals, but by a wider range of perspectives. Companies still benefit from this because they gain access to a stronger and more active community, even if they do not have absolute control.

Taking all of this into account, it becomes clear that the ethical issue is not about rejecting corporate involvement, but about defining its limits. Companies should support, guide, and invest in open source projects, but they should not dominate them. Control should be balanced with accountability, and authority should be shared rather than centralized.

In the end, the OpenOffice.org case demonstrates that when corporate control exceeds ethical boundaries, it does not strengthen a project it weakens it. The loss of trust, the departure of contributors, and the eventual fork into LibreOffice all point to the same conclusion: open source projects cannot succeed in the long run if they are controlled in a way that ignores the community behind them.

Section C: The Forking Question

The decision to fork OpenOffice.org and create LibreOffice was not an easy or obvious one. Forking is often described as a fundamental right in open source, but in reality, it is a risky and costly step. It divides communities, creates confusion among users, and requires rebuilding momentum from scratch. Therefore, the first question to consider is whether forking was truly the right response to the situation with Oracle, or whether the community could have pursued better alternatives.

At first glance, one could argue that the community should have tried to work within Oracle's system instead of breaking away. OpenOffice.org was already a well-established project with millions of users, strong brand recognition, and existing infrastructure. By staying within the system, contributors could have continued improving the software without disrupting users or splitting development efforts. There was also a possibility however uncertain that Oracle might have adjusted its approach over time if the community had engaged more actively or negotiated better terms.

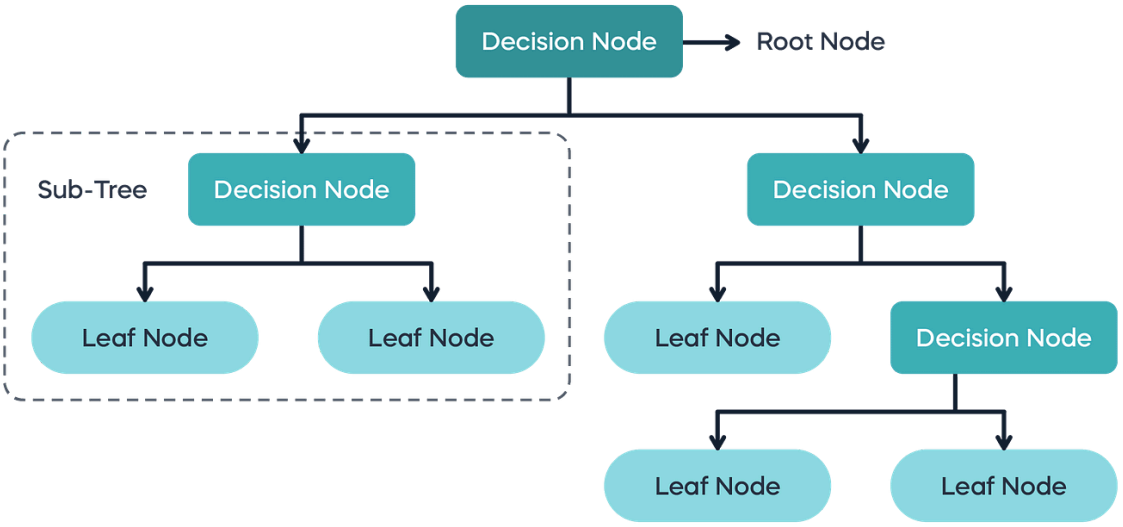

Fig 3: Forking as a Decision Point

However, this argument has limitations. The core issue was not just technical or organizational—it was about trust and control. The community had already experienced years of centralized governance under Sun, and the Oracle acquisition made those concerns more serious. Oracle showed little interest in changing the governance model or involving the community in decision-making. In such a situation, continuing within the same structure would likely have meant accepting a system that many contributors already felt was unfair. Over time, this could have led to reduced participation, slower innovation, and gradual decline.

The decision to fork, therefore, can be seen as a long-term strategic move rather than a short-term reaction. By creating The Document Foundation and launching

LibreOffice, the community chose independence over convenience. They accepted the immediate costs—such as fragmentation and uncertainty in exchange for building a system where governance would be more balanced and transparent.

From Oracle's perspective, refusing to join or support the new foundation might have made sense from a business standpoint. By maintaining control over OpenOffice.org, Oracle retained ownership of a well-known brand and avoided giving up authority to an independent body. From a purely strategic view, companies often prefer to keep control over their assets rather than share it. However, while this decision may have been rational in business terms, it was questionable from an ethical perspective. By refusing to collaborate with the community, Oracle effectively pushed contributors away and weakened the project's long-term viability.

This situation clearly shows that business logic and ethical responsibility do not always align. What seems like a logical decision for a company protecting control and assets—can have negative consequences for the community and the project as a whole. In this case, Oracle's decision contributed to the decline of OpenOffice.org, while LibreOffice, which adopted a more community-focused approach, continued to grow.

Another important issue is whether the cost of forking was worth it. There is no doubt that the fork created confusion. For a period of time, users and organizations were unsure whether to use OpenOffice.org or LibreOffice. Development efforts were split, and resources had to be redistributed. These are real disadvantages, and they cannot be ignored.

However, when we look at the long-term outcome, the benefits of the fork become more visible. LibreOffice managed to attract the majority of active contributors, became the default office suite in most Linux distributions, and gained widespread adoption across the world. In contrast, OpenOffice.org gradually lost momentum. This suggests that while the fork created short-term disruption, it ultimately led to a healthier and more sustainable project.

To fully evaluate the situation, it is also important to construct the strongest possible argument against forking. One could argue that the community acted too quickly and that they should have given Oracle more time to prove its intentions. Forking might be seen as an extreme step that should only be taken when all other options are exhausted. By leaving, the community may have weakened its ability to influence the original project and created unnecessary division.

While this argument is reasonable, it is not entirely convincing. The signs of misalignment between the community and corporate control were already present, and Oracle's actions did not indicate a willingness to change. Waiting longer might not have solved the problem it might have delayed the inevitable while further weakening the community's position. In this sense, the fork can be seen as a proactive decision rather than a reactive one.

In conclusion, the decision to fork OpenOffice.org and create LibreOffice was both risky and necessary. It involved significant costs, including fragmentation and

uncertainty, but it also allowed the community to regain control and build a more balanced governance system. While alternative approaches could have been attempted, they were unlikely to address the deeper issues of trust and authority. The success of LibreOffice suggests that, despite its challenges, the fork was ultimately the right decision.At the same time, the success of LibreOffice does not mean that forking should always be seen as the best solution in similar situations. It is important to understand that not every fork leads to a positive outcome. Many forks fail because they cannot gather enough contributors, lack resources, or fail to build trust among users. What made the LibreOffice fork successful was not just the decision to fork, but the strong support it received from the community and major organizations right from the beginning. Without that collective backing, the fork could have easily failed.

This brings attention to an important factor: timing. The LibreOffice fork happened at a moment when dissatisfaction within the community was already high, and contributors were mentally prepared for change. If the fork had happened earlier, it might not have gained enough support. If it had happened later, the community might have weakened further, making it harder to rebuild. This suggests that forking is not just about having the option it is about choosing the right moment when the conditions are favorable.

Another important aspect is leadership. The formation of The Document Foundation provided a clear direction and structure for the new project. It was not just a random split; it was an organized effort with a defined vision of governance and independence. This gave contributors confidence that they were not just leaving something behind, but moving toward something better. Without such leadership, the fork could have resulted in confusion rather than progress.

It is also worth considering how users were affected during this transition. For developers, the fork was about governance and control, but for users, it created uncertainty. Many organizations rely on stability, especially when it comes to office software. The existence of two similar projects OpenOffice.org and LibreOffice made decision-making difficult. Some users chose to wait, while others hesitated to switch due to fear of compatibility or long-term support issues. This shows that decisions made at the governance level can have real-world impacts on everyday users.

Despite these challenges, the long-term outcome suggests that the community made a calculated and thoughtful decision. Instead of continuing in a system they did not trust, they chose to take responsibility for their own future. This reflects a deeper principle of open source: freedom is meaningful only when it can be exercised, even if doing so is difficult.

Another point to consider is that the fork did not completely destroy the original project it created competition. Apache OpenOffice continued to exist, even if at a reduced scale. This competition can be seen as a healthy outcome of open source ecosystems, where different approaches can coexist and users can choose what suits them best. However, in this case, the difference in growth clearly showed which model was more sustainable.

In the end, the LibreOffice fork highlights that open source is not just about writing code it is about making choices under uncertainty. The community had to balance risks and benefits, short-term disruption and long-term stability, unity and independence. Their decision was not perfect, but it was guided by a clear understanding of what they valued most: control, fairness, and trust.

Therefore, while forking should not be taken lightly, the LibreOffice case shows that it can be a powerful tool when used at the right time and for the right reasons. It is not just an escape from a problem, but an opportunity to rebuild a system in a better and more sustainable way.

Section D: Lessons and Generalisation

The LibreOffice case is not just about one project it reflects a broader pattern in the open source world. When we look at the similar situation with MySQL and its fork into MariaDB, it becomes clear that this was not an isolated incident. Both projects were affected by the same corporate acquisition, and in both cases, the community responded by creating an independent alternative. This repetition suggests that the issue was not specific to OpenOffice.org alone, but rather a deeper structural problem in how corporate ownership interacts with open source communities.

The fact that two major open source projects—OpenOffice.org and MySQL—faced similar crises after coming under Oracle's control shows that community trust is extremely sensitive to changes in governance. When contributors feel that a project is no longer aligned with open source values, they are willing to take drastic steps, even if it means rebuilding everything from scratch. This indicates that trust is not just an emotional factor; it is a critical component of the sustainability of open source projects. Once trust is broken, it is very difficult to restore, no matter how strong the technical foundation of the project may be.

Now consider a hypothetical situation: a large cloud company, referred to as Company X, contributes the majority of code to an open source project and controls its governance, while also using the project to promote its own commercial services. At first glance, this may seem similar to the OpenOffice.org situation. However, whether it is truly the same depends on certain key factors.

One important factor is transparency. If Company X openly communicates its intentions, involves the community in decision-making, and allows independent contributors to influence the project, then its control may be seen as acceptable. On the other hand, if decisions are made internally without consultation, and the community is treated as secondary, then the situation becomes problematic. Transparency helps build trust, even when there is unequal contribution.

Fig 4: Global Open Source Collaboration and Community Network

Another factor is the distribution of power. If a single company has complete control over governance, it creates a risk similar to what happened with OpenOffice.org. But if there are checks and balances—such as independent boards, voting systems, or limits on corporate

influence—then the project is more likely to remain healthy. In other words, control is not the problem by itself; unbalanced control is.

A third factor is alignment of interests. If the company's goals are aligned with the community—such as improving the software for general use—then collaboration can be productive. But if the company primarily uses the project to serve its own commercial interests, without considering the needs of the wider community, then conflict is likely to arise. In the case of Oracle, many contributors felt that the company's priorities were not aligned with theirs, which contributed to the loss of trust.

Based on these observations, it becomes clear that the key issue is not whether a company is involved in an open source project, but how that involvement is structured. This leads to an important question: how can new open source projects avoid the problems that led to the LibreOffice fork?

If I were advising a group of developers starting a new open source project, I would recommend a governance model that ensures balance, transparency, and independence from the beginning. First, there should be no mandatory copyright assignment to a single entity. Contributors should retain ownership of their work, or at most, grant licenses that allow the project to use their contributions without transferring full control. This prevents the concentration of legal power in one organization.

Second, the project should be managed by an independent foundation rather than a single company. This foundation should have clear rules that limit the influence of any one organization, ensuring that decisions are made collectively. For example, no single company should be allowed to dominate the governing board, and important decisions should require agreement from multiple stakeholders.

Third, decision-making processes should be transparent and open to participation. Contributors should have the opportunity to express their opinions, vote on major issues, and understand how decisions are made. This creates a sense of ownership and encourages long-term involvement.

Finally, there should be clear guidelines for corporate participation. Companies should be allowed and even encouraged to contribute resources and developers, but their influence should be balanced with that of independent contributors. This ensures that the project benefits from corporate support without becoming dependent on it.

In conclusion, the LibreOffice case teaches that the success of an open source project depends not only on its technical quality but also on its governance structure. Trust, transparency, and fairness are just as important as code. Projects that ignore these factors may succeed in the short term, but they risk long-term instability. By learning from this case and applying its lessons, future open source projects can avoid similar conflicts and build stronger, more sustainable communities.

Another important lesson from this case is that governance should not be treated as an afterthought. Many projects begin with a focus on technology—writing code, fixing bugs, and building features—while governance structures are either loosely defined or controlled by whoever started the project. This may work in the early stages, but as the project grows, unclear governance can lead to serious conflicts. The LibreOffice case shows that it is much easier to design a fair system from the beginning than to fix an imbalanced system later.

It also highlights the importance of reducing dependency on a single entity. When a project relies too heavily on one company for leadership, funding, or infrastructure, it becomes vulnerable to sudden changes. If that company changes its priorities, gets acquired, or decides to shift direction, the entire project can be affected. A more resilient model is one where multiple organizations and independent contributors share responsibility. This distributes risk and ensures that no single change can destabilize the entire ecosystem.

Another lesson is related to community identity. Open source projects are not just collections of code—they are communities built on shared values and trust. When contributors feel that their values are not respected, they begin to disconnect from the project, even if the technical work continues. In the LibreOffice case, the fork was not just about solving a governance issue; it was about preserving the identity of the community as something independent and collaborative. This shows that maintaining a strong and inclusive culture is just as important as maintaining good code quality.

The case also teaches that conflicts in open source are not necessarily negative. While the fork created division in the short term, it also led to the creation of a healthier system in the long run. Sometimes, conflict exposes underlying problems that would otherwise remain hidden. If handled constructively, it can lead to improvement rather than decline. In this sense, the LibreOffice fork can be seen not just as a break, but as a form of evolution.

It is also worth noting that users play an indirect but important role in shaping the outcome of such situations. When major Linux distributions and organizations chose to adopt LibreOffice instead of OpenOffice.org, they effectively supported the new governance model. This shows that user trust and adoption can reinforce certain values within the open source ecosystem. Projects that align with community expectations are more likely to gain widespread acceptance.

Finally, this case encourages developers and contributors to be more aware and informed about the projects they participate in. It is not enough to look at the license and assume that a project is fully open. Contributors should also consider who controls the project, how decisions are made, and what rights they are giving up. Being aware of these factors can help prevent future situations where contributors feel exploited or excluded.

In the broader sense, the LibreOffice story teaches that open source is not just a technical model—it is a social and ethical system. Its success depends on how well it balances power, trust, and collaboration. By applying these lessons, future projects can create environments where both companies and communities can work together without conflict, ensuring long-term stability and growth.

Section E: Reflection

Before reading this case study, my understanding of open source was quite simple. I used to think that open source mainly meant free software—something whose code is available to everyone and can be modified or used without restrictions. In my mind, it was mostly about technical freedom and accessibility. I never really thought deeply about who controls the project or how decisions are made behind the scenes.

However, after going through the LibreOffice case, my understanding has changed significantly. I now realize that open source is not just about access to code, but also about governance, control, and fairness. A project can be legally open source, but still be controlled in a way that limits the role of contributors. This idea was surprising to me because I had always assumed that “open” automatically meant equal participation. The case clearly showed that this is not always true.

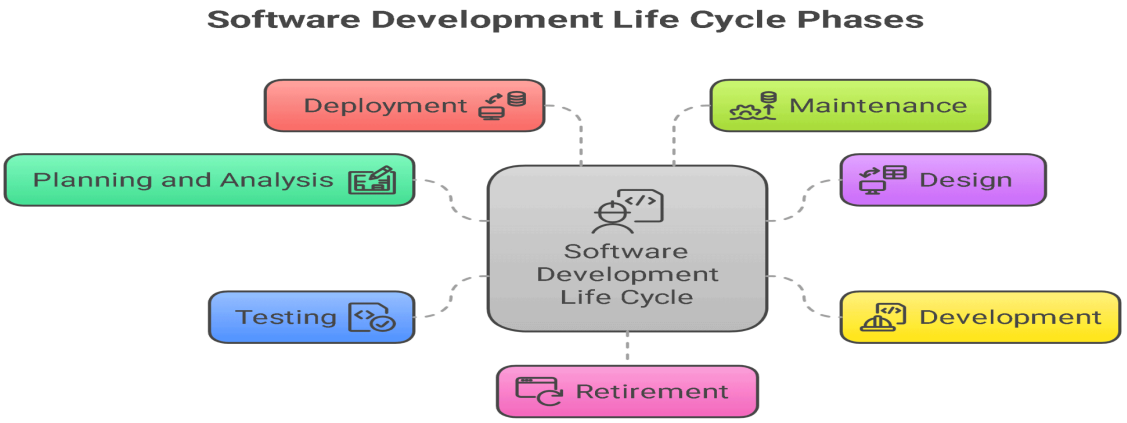

Fig 5: Continuous Learning and Feedback Loop in Software Development

One thing that particularly surprised me was the copyright assignment issue. I had never considered that contributors might have to give up rights to their own work in an open source project. It feels slightly unfair that people who contribute voluntarily may not retain full ownership of what they create. This made me think more critically about how open source projects are structured and how power is distributed within them.

At the same time, I found the reaction of the community quite inspiring. The decision to fork and create LibreOffice was not easy. It involved risk, uncertainty, and a lot of effort. They were leaving behind an established project and starting something new from scratch. What stood out to me was that they chose long-term fairness and independence over short-term convenience. This shows a strong commitment to principles, which is not always easy in practical situations.

Personally, I think the decision to fork was worth it. Even though it created temporary confusion and division, it allowed the community to build a system that better reflected their values. The success of LibreOffice today suggests that their decision was not only justified but also effective. If I were in a similar situation, I believe I would support the fork as well, because working in a system where contributors have no real control does not seem sustainable in the long run.

Another thing that troubled me was how easily trust can be broken. Under Sun, the system had its flaws, but it continued because people trusted the company. Once Oracle took over, that trust disappeared, and the same system became unacceptable. This made me realize that trust is a very fragile but essential part of any collaborative project. Without it, even a technically strong project can fall apart.

Overall, this case has changed the way I look at open source. I now understand that it is not just about software—it is about people, relationships, and values. It involves questions of fairness, ownership, and responsibility, which are not always visible at first. This makes open source much more complex and interesting than I had previously thought.

It also made me reflect on my own future as a developer. If I contribute to an open source project, I would now pay more attention to how the project is governed, not just what it does technically. Earlier, I might have focused only on learning or building skills, but now I understand that the environment in which I contribute also matters. I would prefer to contribute to projects where contributors are respected, where decisions are transparent, and where no single entity has overwhelming control.

Another realization I had is that open source is not always as ideal as it is often presented. We usually hear about its advantages—freedom, collaboration, innovation—but we rarely discuss its internal challenges, such as power imbalance and ethical concerns. This case study exposed that side of open source, making my understanding more realistic. It showed that even systems built on the idea of openness can face issues similar to traditional organizations if governance is not handled properly.

At a personal level, I also felt a sense of respect for the developers who chose to fork. It is easy to continue working in a system that is already established, even if it has problems. It is much harder to step away and rebuild something better. That decision requires confidence, cooperation, and a clear belief in one’s values. This made me think about the importance of standing up for fairness, even when it involves risk.

Finally, this case has left me with an important takeaway: true openness is not just about giving access, but about sharing control. If people are expected to contribute, they should also have a voice. Without that, the system becomes unbalanced, and over time, it can lead to conflict or even collapse. The LibreOffice story shows that when people come together with a shared vision of fairness and independence, they can create something stronger than what existed before.